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Accenture AI Program

Accenture S&C in collaboration with Halfspace

05.05.2026

Module 3: Storytelling

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Introduction to presenters

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Today you will learn about storytelling & how to apply it you your case work

After today's session you will…

- Know how to craft a story
- Be able to illustrate the many ways you can enhance your story with tools and techniques
- Describe how you can deliver effective presentations (incl. stories) with your teammates

Storytelling & structured communication builds on issue based problem solving

DEFINE the problem → **SOLVE** the problem → **COMMUNICATE** the answer

Todays' focus

1. Construct the pyramid
2. Build the story
3. Building individual pages
4. Tell the story

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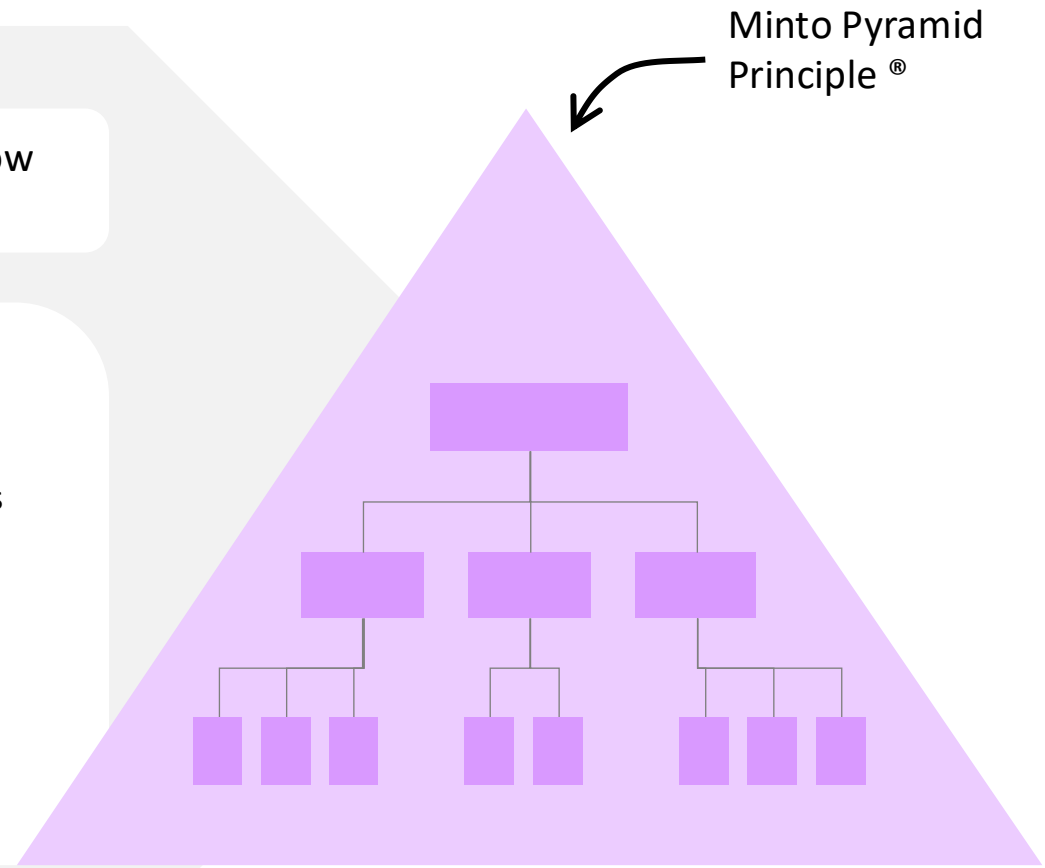
Foundations for building the pyramid: The Pyramid Principle

The **pyramid principle** is based on findings on how the mind works

- The mind automatically sorts information into pyramidal groupings
- Groupings of ideas are easier to understand if it is pre-sorted into a pyramid structure
- This suggests that written documents should be similarly structured
- The pyramid and issue-tree may often have similarities, but are not necessarily the same



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Try to structure your storytelling around 3 parts: Introduction, Conclusion, & Main Body

Introduction

Introduction

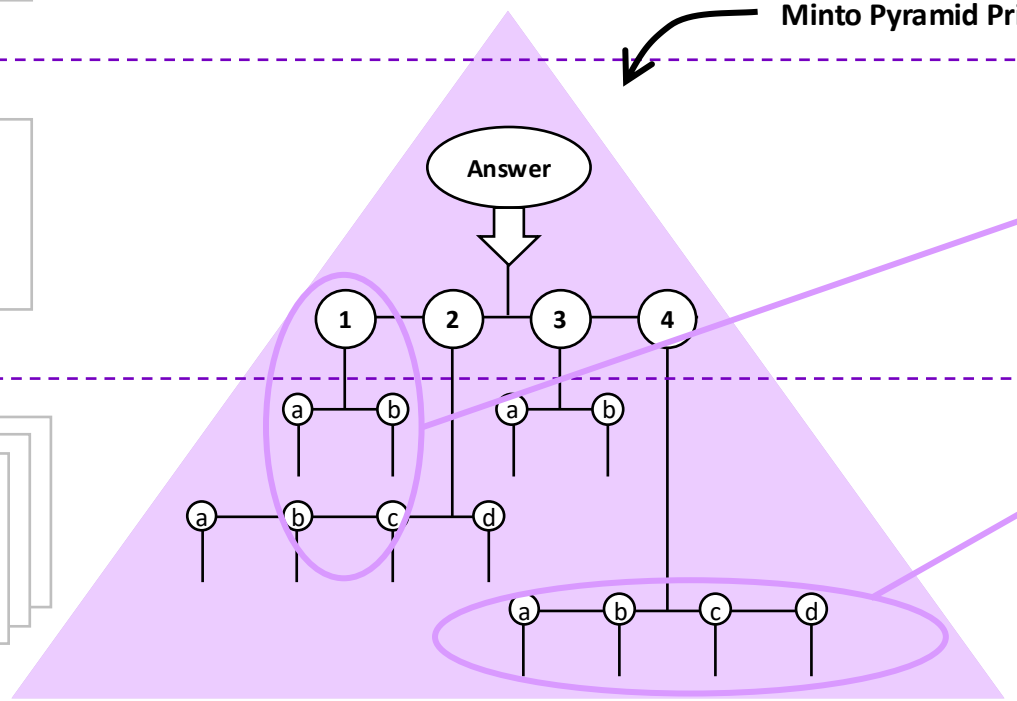
- **Situation**
- **Complication**
- **Question**

Conclusion

Key Messages

Main Body

Support



Rule 1: Vertical grouping
Ideas at any level must summarize the ideas presented below them

Rule 2: Horizontal grouping
Ideas in each grouping must be part of the same argument and presented logically

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Grouping ideas makes the argument clearer & better supports the main message

Guiding principles for grouping arguments

Groups support arguments according to what kind of question they answer

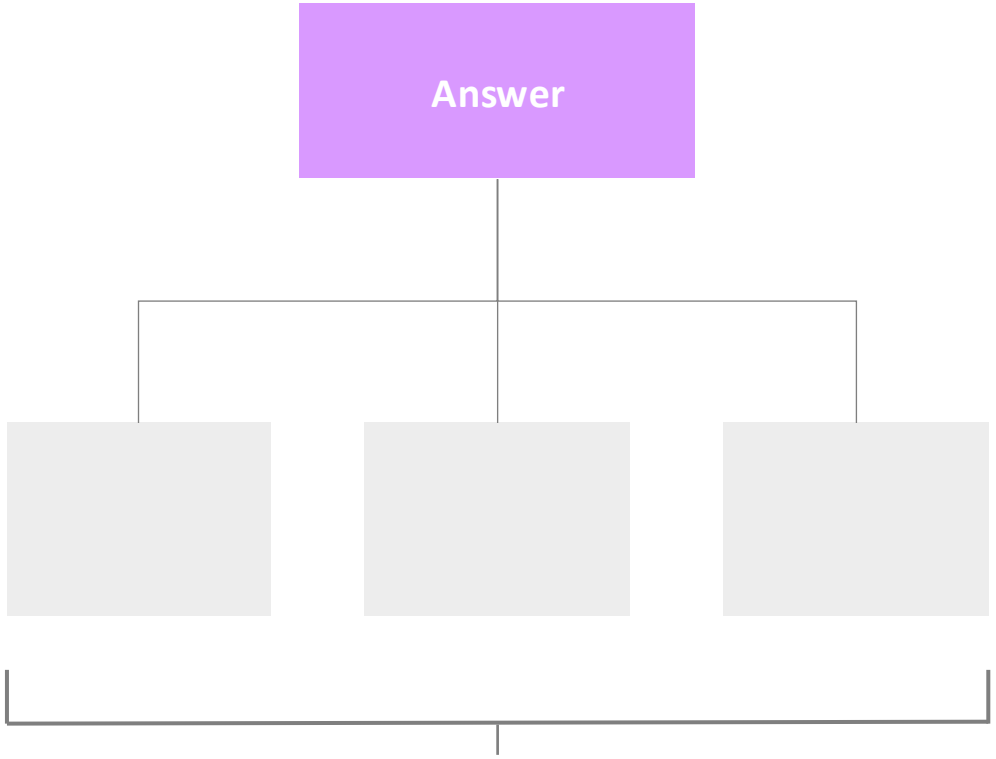
- Why? *Reasons*
- How? *Actions*

The arguments should tell a full story and not overlap

- **M**utually **E**xclusive, **C**ollectively **E**xhaustive (MECE)

Ideas in a group are sequenced logically, e.g.,:

- Chronology
- Structure
- Importance



Grouping of supporting arguments

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EXERCISE | What first level supporting argument is *incorrect*

2 min

First level supporting arguments are rather high level and the audience may ask themselves “why?”

Main message

The electrical car is the ideal mode of transportation for urban people

- *Environmentally friendly*
- *Practical in the urban traffic*
- *Low operating costs*
- *Free charging at the office*
- *Builds a chic, urban image*

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ANSWER | What first level supporting argument is *incorrect*

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EXERCISE | What second level supporting argument is *incorrect*

2 min

Second level supporting arguments are more detailed and provide answers to "why?"

Main message

The electrical car is the ideal mode of transportation for urban people

- *Practical in the urban traffic*
  - *Low to zero carbon emissions*
  - *Allowed to use bus/taxi lane - saving time during rush hours*
  - *Automatic transmission makes it more comfortable in traffic jams and at traffic lights*
  - *Easy to park*
- *Low operating costs*
- *Environmentally friendly*
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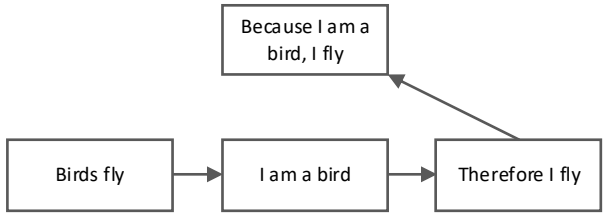
The Pyramid Principle can be applied in an *inductive* or *deductive* way

Inductive

Deductive



Pros

- ✓ Major points are easy to remember - the logic is clear
- ✓ If one point is rejected, the remaining points are still valid

- ✓ Presents a strong line of argument to support a specific conclusion
- ✓ Presents all conclusions at the same time

Cons

- ✗ Can be too aggressive for some audiences

- ✗ Disagreement with any of the logic means the argument may fail to persuade
- ✗ Audience must remember the entire “line of argument”

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Strong solutions create little value if the story is unclear

In consulting, storytelling is not decoration. It is how good work becomes understandable, credible, & decision-ready.

What students often do

- **Focus on features** without providing business context
- **Explain every detail** causing exhaustion
- **Present what was built** forgetting why

What consultants do

- **Start with the problem** ensuring alignment with audience
- **Guide the audience logically** helping them follow along
- **Show why the answer matters** enabling coupling

The role of storytelling is to turn analysis and prototypes into client confidence.
It is not a soft add-on; it is a core consulting skill.

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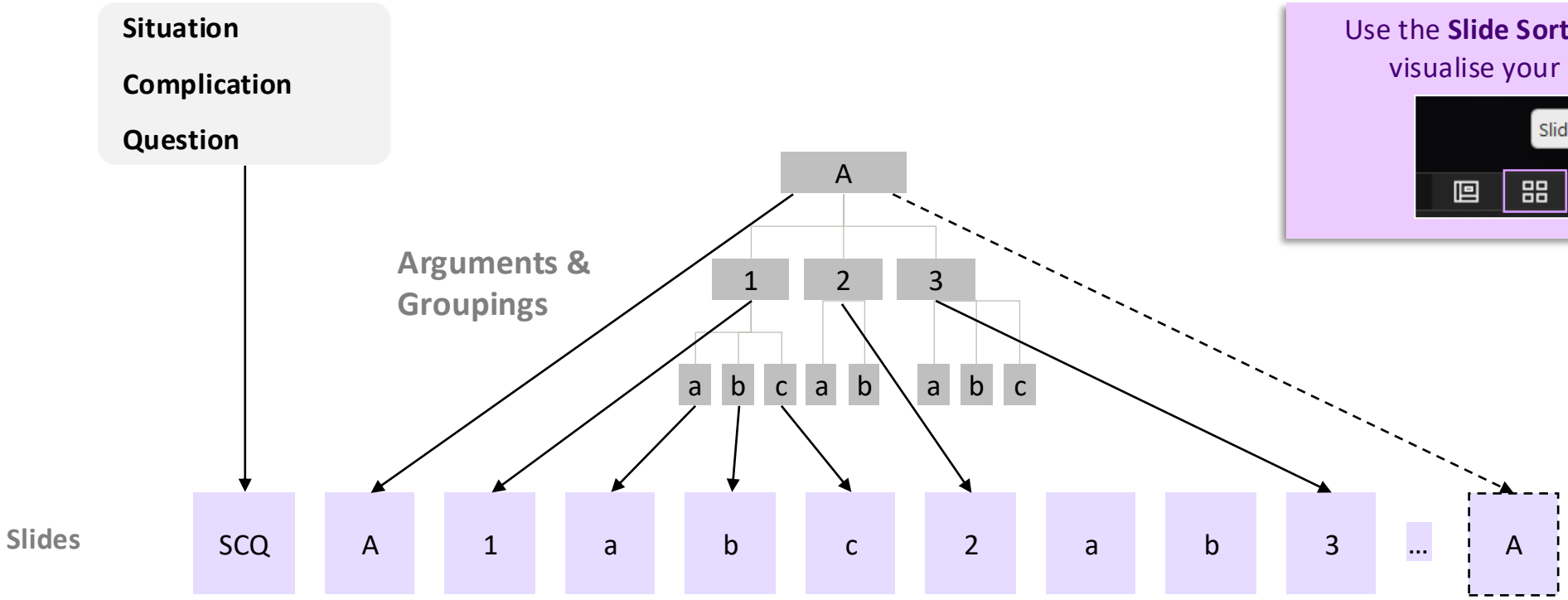
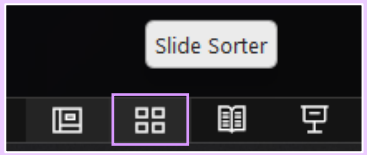
You can use a storyboard to link the pyramid to individual slides with one major idea per slide



Use the **Slide Sorter** to view and visualise your storyboard



Guiding questions you can ask yourself

1. *How many pages will we create?*
2. *How will each page help tell the story mapped in the pyramid?*

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Taglines & titles should state the conclusion of the page

Bad taglines

- ✗ Market size
- ✗ System requirements
- ✗ Implementation plan
- ✗ What is the size of the market?
- ✗ What are the system requirements?
- ✗ How should we go about implementing the necessary steps?

Well formulated taglines

- ✓ The market is big enough for client X to prosper
- ✓ The main system requirement is interoperability with SAP
- ✓ The key to implementation success is early buy-in from the vice presidents

Action titles are key to conveying the main take ways and the logical order of your story

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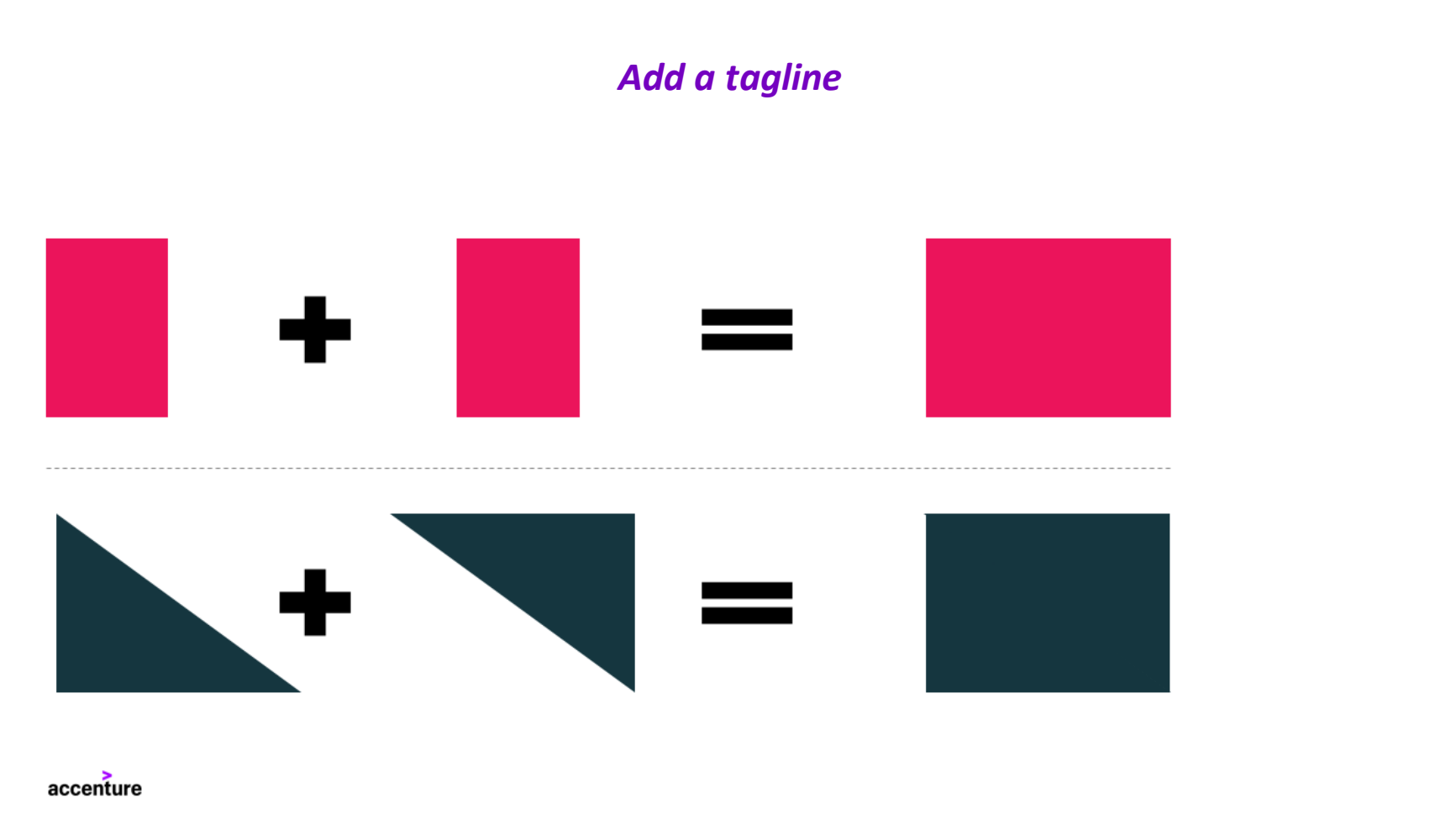
EXERCISE | What is the main message of the slide? Construct a fitting tagline

2 min



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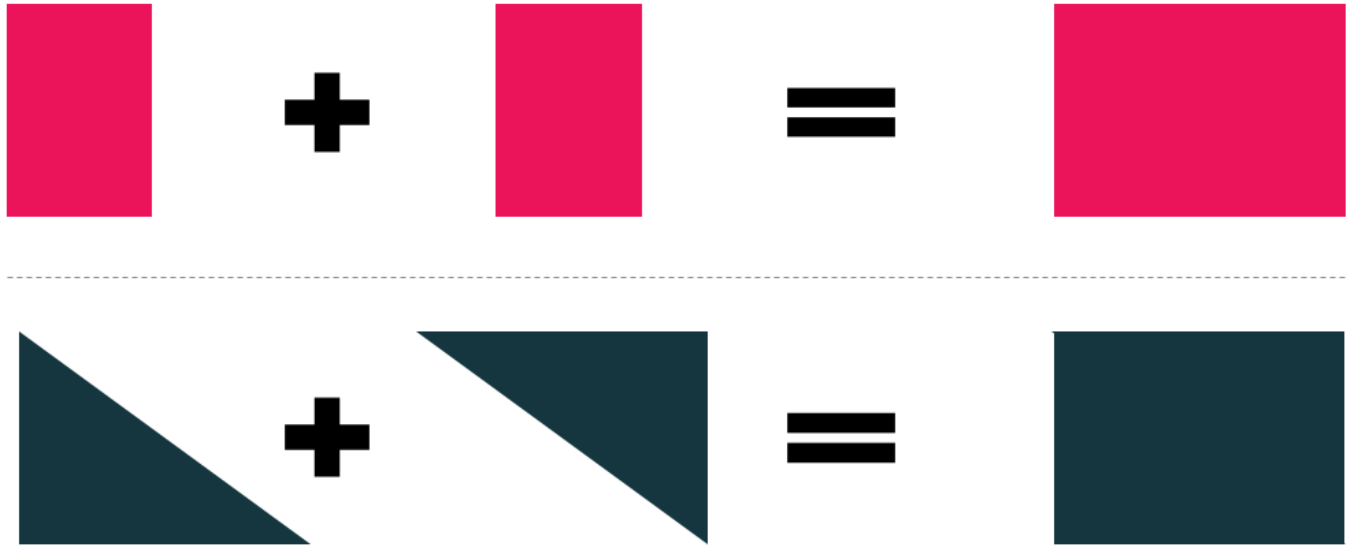
ANSWER | What is the main message of the slide? Construct a fitting tagline

You can make a square in more than one way



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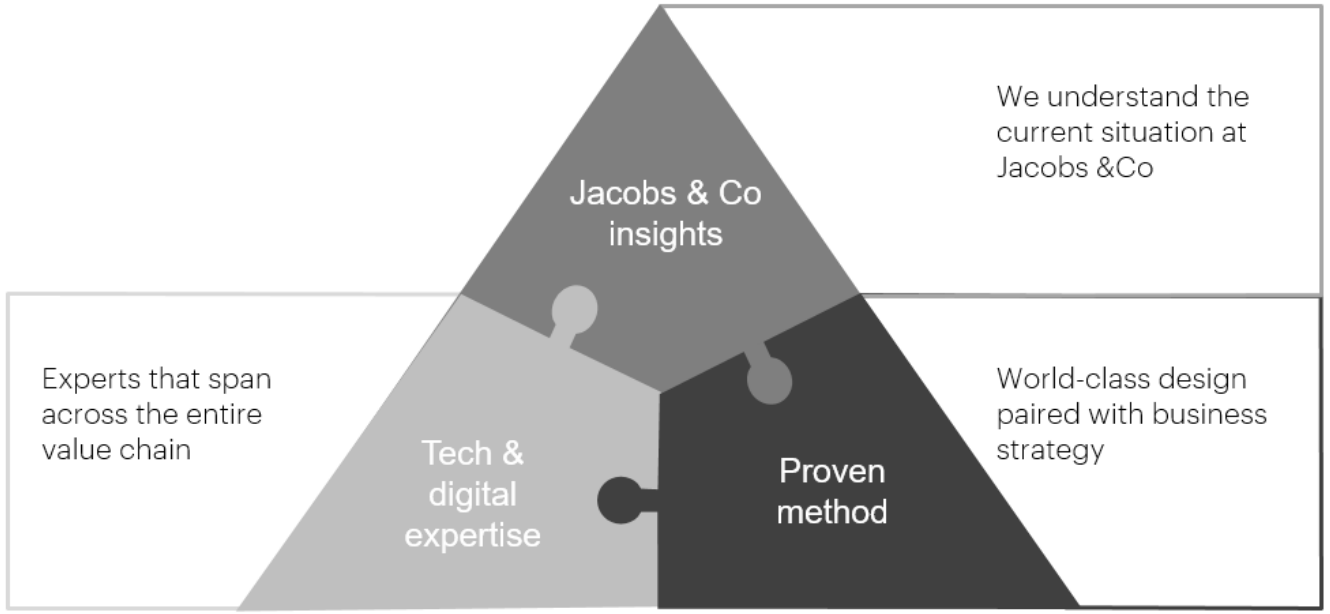
EXERCISE | What is the main message of the slide? Construct a fitting tagline

2 min

Add a tagline



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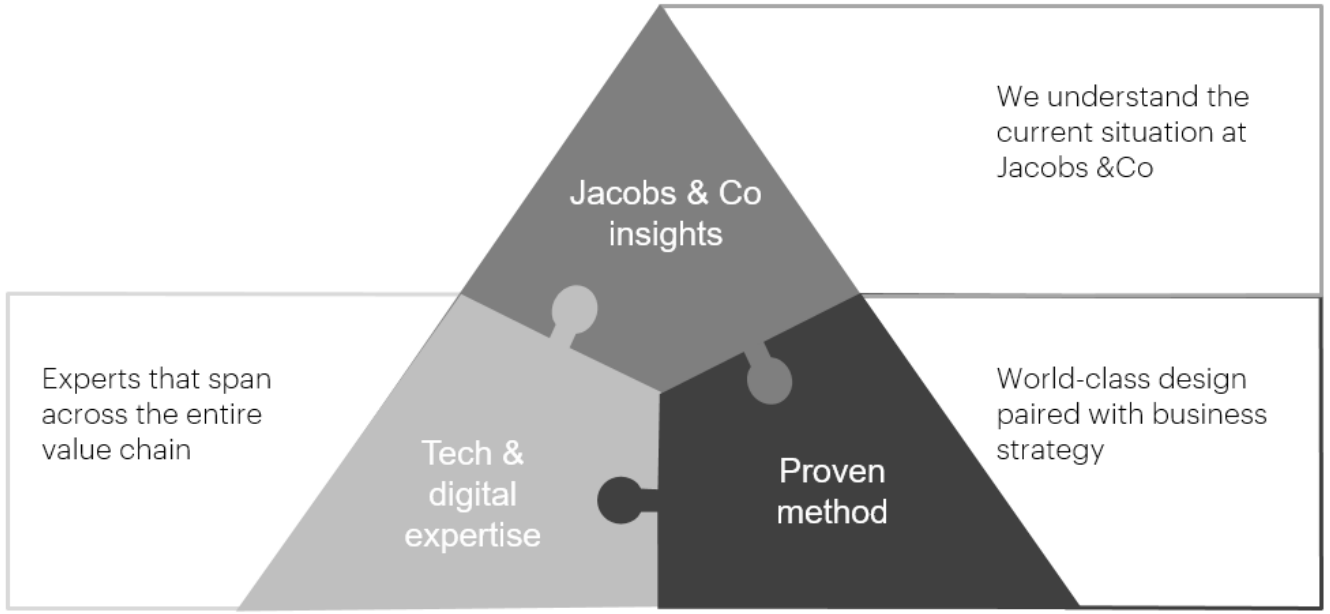
ANSWER | What is the main message of the slide? Construct a fitting tagline

JACOBS & CO NEEDS A PARTNER WHO KNOWS THEM, HAS THE INDUSTRY KNOWLEDGE, AND THE PROVEN METHODOLOGY TO DELIVER RESULTS

Accenture's unique mix of expertise



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The best presentations are selective: they include only what advances the argument

Storytelling in consulting is as much about what you **leave out** as what you put in.

Include

- Business relevance
- One clear line of logic
- Evidence that supports the recommendation
- Implications and next steps

Exclude

- Every piece of analysis*
- Technical detail without business meaning
- Background without purpose
- Buzzwords without insight

**Relevant items can be included in an appendix*

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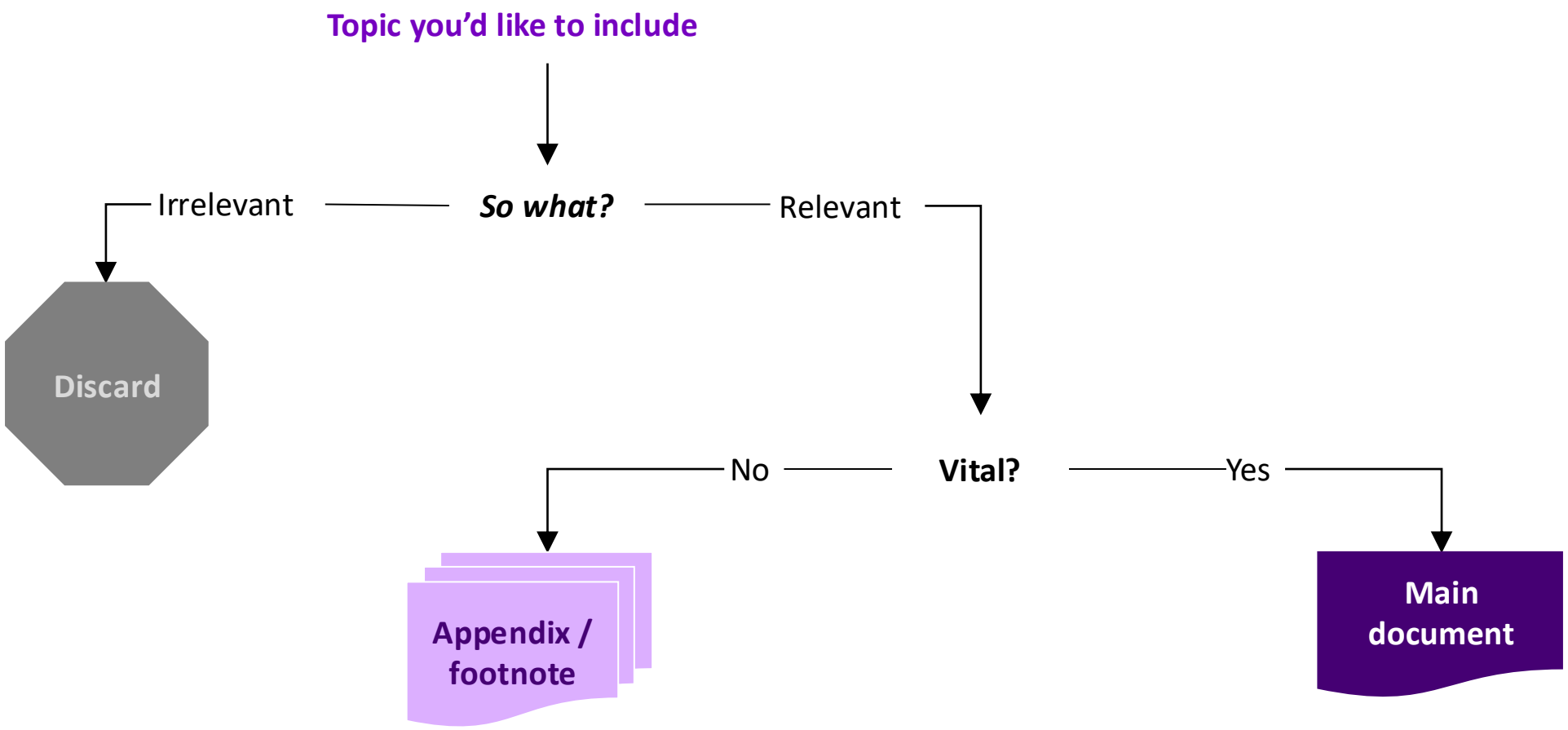
Asking the "so what?" question ensures only relevant & vital topics are kept in the presentation



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We recommend applying these 4 principles when building slides…

1

Create a common theme

Ensure that the deck is consistent (color, font, boxes, headlines) and leaves the reviewer with the impression of a natural story

2

Start by drafting it on paper

How can you visualize what you want to tell your audience? How should the slide be structured?

3

Fill in the content you want to present

Use simple boxes without over-engineered visuals to show your messages. Remember, one slide should only tell one main message

4

Steal with pride

Ensure to re-use good slides, there is no reason to re-produce good visuals or decks

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… And some tips & tricks to making slides look better

ALIGN, ALIGN, ALIGN

Remember to align all boxes, texts, and figures on the slides to prevent a ”messy” impression. Make use of alignment tools to speed up the work

AVOID USING SAME LAYOUT FOR DIFFERENT CONCEPTS

Graphical memory is often stronger than words. Avoid reusing the same graphical layout for different concepts to make sure you don’t confuse the audience

MAKE IT PRETTY

Even if the key message is about cost reduction, you can still make it look nice. Use illustrations, icons, and figures to visualize your message

BACK TO THE BASICS

Never submit slides without spell checking. Bullet-proof your writing by checking sentence building and wording one extra time – or ask a teammate for help

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Does your story make the audience trust your recommendation?

Self-assess your story and pitch

- Is the problem clear from the start?
- Is the solution linked directly to the problem?
- Is the technical explanation at the right level?
- Is the value creation explicit?
- Are the next steps realistic?

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Before you develop & present your content, you should carefully consider the purpose of the presentation

Know as much as you can about the target audience before you plan your presentation.
4 dimensions to consider:

1 Demographics

- Who
- Education
- Seniority/Level

2 Motivation

- What are they interested in
- What do they expect

3 Understanding

- What do they already know

4 Setting

- Internal vs External
- Formality

TIPS & TRICKS

Know your client

Less is more

Steal with pride

Illustrations say more than words

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When communicating, you need to know who you audience is

- Risk-adverse
- Slower-paced
- Cautious action
- Structured
- Wants to see the detail

ANALYTICAL

DRIVER

- Faster-paced
- Structured
- Practical
- Interested in results and speed
- Tomorrow timeframe

"Controls"

Responsiveness

"Asks" **Assertiveness** "Tells"

"Emotes"

- Risk-adverse
- Slower-paced
- Very relationship-oriented
- Wants harmony and consensus
- Present timeframe

AMIABLE

EXPRESSIVE

- Faster-paced
- Unstructured
- Impulsive action
- Focused on innovation and vision
- Future timeframe

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Effective presentation structure is key to delivering your message

Clarity is crucial

Strong analysis is worthless if you can’t explain your ideas clearly and convincingly

Make it easy to follow

Being right means little if your audience doesn’t understand your message

Think like the audience

Plan your flow in advance by considering what matters most to your listerners

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Vocal skills are important to be heard and are usually divided into four critical characteristics

Vocal characteristics – The 4 P's	Content
Projection	• Project to the back of the room so everyone can hear you clearly • Adjust your volume strategically
Pitch	• Vary the tone of your speech • Watch the pitch at the end of your sentences
Pace	• Change your delivery rate throughout the presentation • Beware of pace extremes that could be distracting
Pause	• Give the audience a chance to absorb and reflect • Give yourself a chance to breathe and collect your thoughts • Use pauses to help eliminate filler words

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There are 3 main visual characteristics of a presenter: eyes, gestures, & movement

Eye contact

- Establish eye contact with a single member of the audience (zone coverage if necessary)
- Hold the eye contact for the duration of one complete thought if possible

Hands & arm gestures

- Use large gestures to emphasize or demonstrate points of your message
- Return your hands/arms to neutral position at sides when not gesturing
- Create the condition for gesturing, not the gesture itself

Placement & movement

- Move strategically (for emphasis and variety)
- Stop and plant your feet solidly
- Play with pauses while you walk

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To sum up, constructing a compelling story takes practice, effort, & deliberate reflection

1. **Construct the pyramid** — Build a **strong** and **logical case** enabling your story
2. **Build the story** — Craft your **story** with a **clear** and **consistent structure**
3. **Building individual pages** — Be **selective with your content** and make it **appealing**
4. **Tell the story** — **Know your audience** and **rehearse** your pitch

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